

THE MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA

South African Cheese Festival, Stellenbosch

This is South Africa's biggest cheese festival, with over 200 palate-tingling varieties and a veritable cornucopia of accompaniments. Meander through the story of milk from the udder to the plate while the kids try their hand at milking, then relax by the waterfront with a tasting plate and unforgettable views of a Table Mountain sunset. www.cheesefestival.co.za

Taam Hair (A Taste of Tel Aviv), Israel

Indulge all of your senses at this explosion of sounds, sights, smells, and superb samplings from top Israeli chefs and vintners. Tour the culinary booths and take your pick of the tastes, eat while strolling through Hayarkon Park or sitting on the grass, or simply dance with thousands of party-goers.

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Cheung Chau Bun Festival, Hong Kong

In one of the world's most exciting festivals, residents of Cheung Chau dress in colorful costumes and parade through the streets to commemorate the sea god Pak Tai. At midnight on the last day, teams race up 60-ft (18-m) towers to collect buns, which are then handed out to revelers.

NORTH AMERICA

Castroville Artichoke Festival, Monterey County, California, USA

In 1948, Marilyn Monroe was crowned Castroville's first Artichoke Queen — what finer pedigree could a festival have than that? Try this delicious edible bud fried, pickled, marinated, sautéed, griddled, or creamed, and sip silky California wines, all in this quaint little town at the heart of artichoke country. www.artichoke-festival.org

Maui Onion Festival, Lahaina, Hawaii, USA

Sweet, juicy Maui onions are prized by chefs and they're the star of the show here at Whaler's Village in a full day and evening of events, including chef demonstrations, a Best Onion Recipe contest, a Raw Onion Eating challenge, island music, and fine dining. www.whalersvillage.com/onionfestival.htm

Toledo Cacao-Fest, Belize

True chocoholics should make a pilgrimage to the land where cocoa ripens in the tropical sun, to see it being grown, harvested, and processed the traditional, handmade way into the food of the (Mayan) gods. It's all possible in this idyllic reef-and-rain forest setting, along with a gourmet Wine and Chocolate dinner, cultural events, and a spectacular festival finale of music and fireworks.

JUNE

EUROPE

Vlaggetjesdag, Scheveningen, Netherlands

"Flag Day" is named for the bright pennants that flutter from the rigging of the herring boats as they race the first of the new season's catch back to Scheveningen to be auctioned. Thousands line the quay to watch them arrive, listen to sea shanties, and, most importantly, eat herring — pickled, smoked, or even raw. www.vlaggetjesdag.com

La Grande Bufala, Eboli, Italy

Everyone agrees that buffalo-milk mozzarella is the best, and Eboli believes its Mozzarella di Bufala Campagna is the best of all. Leafy Piazza della Repubblica is the showcase for everything to do with this unctuously soft and milky cheese, offering tastings, workshops, and other events lauding all things deliciously Mediterranean.

Batalla del Vino, Haro, Spain

Every June 29, the normally sedate town of Haro, in La Rioja, goes wine-crazy. Revelers armed with buckets, bottles, and even water pistols full of wine launch into pitched battles during which everyone ends up soaking wet and purple from head to toe. It's all good-natured and ends with uproarious feasting and a lot more wine — quaffed, rather than thrown.

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V&A Waterfront Wine Affair, Cape Town, South Africa

Over 70 of the Western Cape's top wineries come together in this gorgeous water's-edge setting. Gourmet food is on hand as well, so visitors can match the perfect Pinotage to charcuterie or grilled ostrich fillet, or sip Sauvignon Blanc with ocean-fresh oysters. No need to fret over which wine route to drive — you can tour them all here in one place.

Feria Oramena, Taolagnaro, Madagascar

Beautiful Fort-Dauphin Bay is the backdrop to this culinary carnival in honor of the delicious and abundant seafood of Madagascar — notably the spiny lobster (*oramera*), which is the heart of the banquet. Enjoy the best of the fun down on the Esplanade by the Town Hall.

Fête des Goyaviers, La Plaine des Palmistes, Réunion

Perched high on Réunion's lush slopes, La Plaine des Palmistes may be the smallest community but it has the biggest presence during this island-wide celebration of the fragrant and versatile guava. It's a lively time of tastings, music, dance, and stories, and it's almost impossible to come away without at least one jar of delicious guava jam.

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Chanthaburi Fruit Festival, Thailand

An exotic and mouthwatering celebration of "the fruit bowl of Thailand." Pluck rambutan, mangosteen, and longan fresh from the trees. Taste the ripest mangos, zalaccas, and custard apples and savor the "king of fruits," the soft and creamy durian. Parades of multicolored fruit floats, regional music, and beauty pageants are all part of the experience.

A Taste of Manly, Sydney, Australia

Manly was once described as "seven miles from Sydney and a thousand miles from care." With stands serving high-quality Australian, Indian, Malaysian, Thai, African, and Mediterranean cuisine, supported by popular New South Wales wines, this seaside festival attracts over 30,000 visitors, with world music, jazz, street performers, and beach games for the whole family.

NORTH AMERICA

Taste of Chicago, Illinois, USA

Lovely lakeside Grant Park is the venue for the "World's Biggest Food Festival," a ten-day event that takes place in the run-up to Independence Day. All the city's top restaurants are represented, offering "taster" plates so that the 3-million-plus visitors can try as many dishes as possible, from classic Chicago deep-pan pizza to iconic Eli's cheesecake.

Arcata Main Street Oyster Festival, California, USA

Arcata Bay, a stunning, almost landlocked circle of blue water in northern California, provides 70 percent of the state's oysters. The citizens of Arcata are proud of their tasty mollusks and love to show them off at this friendly festival, when local chefs serve them every which way, from raw to barbecued, and fearless gourmets compete in the "Shuck and Swallow" contest. www.oysterfestival.net

From left to right Crowds armed with "wine-pistols" at La Batalla del Vino in Haro, Spain; contestants scramble for buns up a 60-ft (18-m) tower at the Cheung Chau Bun Festival in Hong Kong; sidewalks are taken over by hundreds of food stands at the Taste of Chicago food festival; bunting decorates stands preparing and selling herring during Vlaggetjesdag in the Netherlands

